

Working Paper



Agentic Capacity

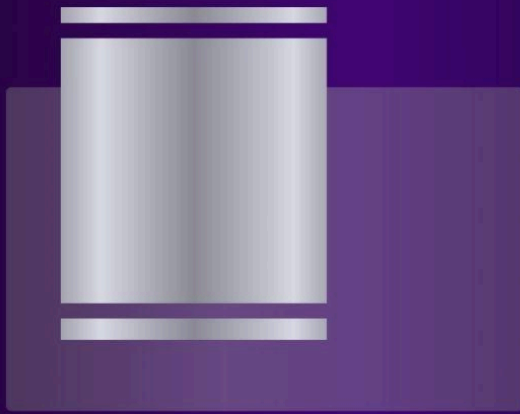
**THE ROLE OF STATES IN
CREATING ECONOMIC GROWTH,
PROVIDING PUBLIC GOODS, AND
ESTABLISHING POLITICAL
STABILITY**

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Abstract

This study – an assessment of how democratic and autocratic regimes behave in the international arena – begins with an exposition of extant attempts made by academics (Beck and Hüser, 2015; Clarke and Stone, 2008; Diamond, 1992; Gascoigne, 2001; Huntington, 1991) to expand the criteria for democracy. Highlighting the role of conflict in juxtaposition to the notion that varying degrees of democracy exist, this study asserts that neatly carved out constructions of democratic and autocratic regimes are possible only in theory.

State strength or weakness can be envisioned using a plethora of approaches – most of which point to a complex mix of intervening variables that contribute to the dynamics of a state that is either working or failing. Literature¹ on failed states usually frame state capability in terms of the state's ability to maintain political order or prevent large-scale instability or civil strife. State failure can also be viewed as wide-spread inability to provide timely assistance during (and in the aftermath of) major disasters – case in point: Hurricane Katrina, which hit New Orleans in 2005, or the 2004 Tsunami in Pakistan. Within the borders of a functioning state, there are several component requirements that are not only essential for institutions to operate at the optimal level, but that also inoculate the state against civil disobedience and conflict. This paper identifies said components required to ensure a state functions optimally, and assesses how certain states structure basic civil liberties – in turn, these basic liberties serve as key differentiators between autocratic and democratic regimes.

Introduction

Kahl (2006) conceptualizes a state as an entity operating within two dimensions²: Foremost – within the structural or institutional dimension – a state is composed of a set of institutions and organizations, each assigned with specific functioning capacities. Secondly – within the agentic dimension – a state can structurally be defined as an entity that assigns agents/individuals both to lead designated organizations, and to act on behalf of the state within specified institutional frameworks. So, in essence, states can bear dual functional and agentic capacities allowing them to function optimally in providing basic services to their citizens.

Regarding the institutional dimension that governs state activities, Kahl (2006) posits that the first crucial component to an optimally functioning institution is dependent upon the coercive capacity (i.e., robustness of policing, intelligence, and security services) of the state to which said institution belongs.

¹ See Acemoglu and Robinson, 2012; Arowolo, 2024; Brainard et al. 2007; Kahl, 1998; Oechslin, 2014; Wendt, 1992.

² Kahl, C. H. (2006). *States, Scarcity, and Civil Strife in the Developing World*. Princeton and Oxford: Princeton University Press.

Considering viewpoints based on democratic ideals, a police state is not the ideal conceptualization of a functioning state – nevertheless, from a stability perspective, there are some efficient police states that are able to maintain political order (but at a high international audience cost). For example, Saudi Arabia and North Korea can be conceptualized as police states – although Saudi Arabia has proven to be better able to provide for the basic needs of its citizens (non-renewable resource advantage); whilst North Korea, crippled by international sanctions, does not have a comparable natural resource advantage to the non-renewable sources which sustain Saudi Arabia.

Kahl (2006) proposes a second critical component to the institutional dimension framework: A state's administrative capacity. If coercive capacity is the ability to both deter/repress violence, and also prevent the outbreak of violence from spiraling into nationwide disorder, then the administrative counterpart of the institutional continuum is cooptation. The cooptation capacity of state institutions – under the state's administrative umbrella – is the state's ability to: a) provide basic services to its citizenry; b) prevent grievances from spiraling out of control; and, c) address emergencies before they evolve into mass disorder (Gerschewski, 2013; Kahl, 2006).

Legitimacy

Legitimacy is an important attribute of a functioning state. Beyond the above-mentioned coercive and administrative capacities of a functioning state, Kahl (2006) identifies legitimacy as a third institutional aspect of state capacity. Political science literature (Lipset, 1959; Gerschewski, 2013) generally defines legitimacy as the right to rule. The vertical legitimacy of a state refers to its systemic, political institutions. The literature (Rogowski, 1987; Lipset, 1959; Gerschewski, 2013; Kahl, 2006) suggests that democracies are perceived as possessing higher internal/systemic legitimacy than authoritarian countries.

A strong authoritarian state is likely to compromise for its low legitimacy status by being high on the coercive (robustness of policing, intelligence, and security services) and administrative (provision of basic services, prevention of grievance escalation, timely emergency management) aspects of the institutional spectrum (Kahl, 2006). China, for example, compensates for being low on legitimacy on the international stage by being high on the coercive and administrative ends of its domestic policies³, which allow the country to remain a highly competitive international trading partner, despite perceptions of low legitimacy associated with her humanitarian missteps.

A second aspect of state legitimacy is horizontal in nature – this aspect examines whether or not a state is fully representative of its local communities.⁴

³ See Mertha (2009); Wang, S., & Hu, A. (2001); and Holsti (1996).

⁴ Ibid 2.

Rogowski (1987) explains that countries experience variations in cleavage patterns because of “ancient cultural loyalties, wars and migration, or historical memories”.⁵ As an example, Kahl (2006) explains that the constitution of Iraq is considerably democratic, but the average Sunni may not ascribe to the idea that the state of Iraq fully represents him/her (on the basis that the Shias have more representative control of the government). Nor is the average Sunni likely to concede that the government of Iraq provides for his/her basic needs (on the basis that local Shias may have better access to government sponsored programs, provisions, etc.). The Iraq reference exemplifies cultural or political cleavages. As such, a state may have a degree of vertical legitimacy (based on its institutions), but may be low on horizontal legitimacy for failing to fully represent/provide for the needs of certain communities.

Gerschewski (2013) takes the Weberian approach in conceptualizing legitimation as the process of gaining support, via active consent and compliance with the rules. The Weberian approach crystalizes the notion that an elected official or government has legitimacy in rulership. Weberian sociology treats legitimacy not as an objective truth, but as an empirical truth, canonized in the subjective philosophy of citizens (Hardy & Clegg, 1996). Legitimacy matters to how well a state functions because state laws, at once, embody the logic of consequences and the logic of appropriateness (Kahl, 2006). States maintain order much in the same manner (i.e., in alignment with the logic of consequences) – those who rebel against the state will face the consequences (jail or capital punishment). Legitimate states also uphold that differences be settled, not through violence, but rather via votes at the ballot box.

The agentic dimension

The agentic dimension of the state, as Kahl (2006) explains, requires that both human agency (leadership) and state functions foster an environment that allows for the coordination and collaboration of activities that provide services for the citizenry. It is possible to have a very capable state, like the United States, that struggles to coordinate its activities, and thereby failing in spectacular ways either at the domestic level (for example, Hurricane Katrina), or at the international level (Iraq war). Highlighting inconsistencies in the U.S. approach to exporting democracy to failed or failing autocratic regimes, Windsor (2007) explains that, until recent reforms made to the U.S. foreign assistance process, U.S. government administrations had a tendency “to simply create new offices and organizations to address development, democracy, and conflict goals, without integrating (and reforming) existing units into the new process”⁶. The result was uncoordinated efforts and wasted resources in the realm of foreign assistance.

⁵ Rogowski, Ronald. 1987. Political cleavages and changing exposure to trade. Pg. 1133.

⁶ Windsor, J. 2007. Chapter 10: Breaking the Poverty-Insecurity Nexus: Is Democracy the Answer? In Lael Brainard and Derek Chollet, Editors (Eds.), *Too Poor for Peace? Global Poverty, Conflict and Security in the 21st Century*. Brookings Institution Press. Pg. 160.

The jury is still out concerning whether the more recent attempts to unify functional foreign assistance bureaus will yield better results in terms of efficiently administering tax dollars towards international assistance and development projects.⁷

Rice (2007) explains that state capacity is a state's ability to deliver basic functions to its citizens, which directly depends on the state's administrative operations – including border control, which has an impact on neighborhood effects – e.g., reduction in contributions to the local economy (i.e., less customers), and high enforcement activity (which leads to fear and may engender sentiments of mistrust in public institutions among those who disagree with the enforcement approach). Brainard et al. (2007) explain that, based on political science dogma, there is a U-shaped relationship between stability and political institutions: For states in transition, the issue with the stability of political institutions emerges during the transitional period between autocracy and democratic rule. Rice (2007) explains that human agency is a critical aspect of political stability – especially in weak institutional contexts, where the quality of leadership will be heavily consequential during political transitions.

In Botswana, for example, Rice (2007) points out that, during transitional phases, a set of traditional customs were transplanted into the newly democratizing state, which created an environment wherein a series of responsible presidents were able to lead the country out of poverty and into economic stability. This is in contrast to Zimbabwe, where in 2000, even though the country had all the requisites for a thriving economy, weak institutions and poor agentic capacity gave way, not only to the rise of Robert Mugabe, but also precipitated a national reversal of fortunes within a very short period of time (Rice, 2007). The take-away here is that, the weaker a state's institutions are, the more control agentic influences can have on a state's economic landscape – either to the benefit or the detriment of the state in question.

War and state institutions

Weak institutions undergird the poverty and insecurity nexus, which provides breeding ground for political instability (Brainard, Chollet, and LaFleur, 2007). War is central to a nation's development capabilities (Miguel and Blattman, 2010); and state-sponsored activity in the aftermath of war is a crucial determinant in determining whether the state itself recovers or remains in perpetual failure. Rice (2007) provides examples with good analytical grounding – citing the U.K. Department for International Development – in explaining that a country with \$250 per capita income has a 15% likelihood of internal conflict over a projected five-year period; in contrast, for an economy with per capita income registering at \$5,000 or more, the assessed level of risk is greater than 1%⁸.

⁷ Ibid 2.

⁸ See Jeremy M. Weinstein, John Edward Porter, and Stuart E. Eizenstat, *On the Brink: Weak States and U.S. National Security* (Washington: Center for Global Development, 2004); Woodrow Wilson International Center for Scholars, *Preventing the Next Wave of Conflict: Understanding Non-Traditional Threats to Global Stability* (Washington, 2003); and Susan E. Rice, "Poverty Breeds Insecurity," in this volume. Also see U.S. Agency for

Considering populations living in poverty, research⁹ suggests that, because almost one-third of civil wars ultimately reignite, upwards of 30% more people (in conflict zones) end up living in poverty, when compared to conflict-free zones¹⁰. Therefore, conflict (in and of itself) is both a reliable predictor of the likelihood of future conflict/political instability, and is also a robust estimator in gauging poverty-inducing factors.

Kahl (2007)¹¹ identifies large scale civil strife, or organized political violence within a country as the causal variable in specifying the equation for a properly functioning state. According to Miguel (2007), “the poverty-violence link is arguably the most robust finding in the growing research literature investigating the causes of civil wars” that discernably cripple a state’s economic capabilities¹² (p. 51). Analyzing the impact of purely exogenous economic shocks on poverty and the eventual propensity for state conflict, Miguel finds that: “The size of the estimated impact of lagged economic growth on conflict is huge ... a 1 percentage point decline in gross domestic product increases the likelihood of civil conflict by more than 2 percentage points.”¹³ The implication of this finding is that if an external shock leads to, say, a 5% drop in per capita income in one fiscal year, then the likelihood of a civil conflict (in the year immediately following said external shock) increases by nearly 10% – a very substantial effect.¹⁴

Extreme poverty exhausts governing institutions, depletes resources and weakens leadership – in the sense that the ability to leverage influence on the global stage is not as solid as expectations would warrant. Poor states are also fragile – in the sense that violence can erupt at any point in time, and governments of these states are, oftentimes, too weak to provide adequate responses, on all fronts (Brainard, Chollet and LaFleur, 2007). Scholarly dialogue¹⁵ concerning the relationship between demography, the environment, and civil strife has assessed how these factors can hinder state functions. The most common environmental argument is one that originates from the neo-Malthusian school of thought – this argument is based on the deprivation hypothesis, which is most closely linked to the notion of poverty (Kahl, 2006).

International Development, *State Failure Task Force Reports*, 1998–2000, USAID Fragile States and Conflict Mitigation Strategies (www.usaid.gov [July 2006]).

⁹ Larry Diamond, “Economic Development and Democracy Reconsidered,” in *Reexamining Democracy: Essays in Honor of Seymour Martin Lipset*, ed. Gary Mark (Thousand Oaks, Calif.: Sage Publications, 1992); Amartya Sen, *Development as Freedom* (New York: Random House, 1999), 149–51; United Nations Development Program, *Human Development Report 2002* (New York, 2002), 56.

¹⁰ See Freedom House website (www.freedomhouse.org) for further information on this finding.

¹¹ Kahl, C. H. (2007). Chapter 4: Demography, Environment, and Civil Strife. In Lael Brainard and Derek Chollet, Editors (Eds.), *Too Poor for Peace? Global Poverty, Conflict and Security in the 21st Century*. Brookings Institution Press.

¹² See pages 50–59: Miguel, E. (2007). Chapter 3: Poverty and Violence: An Overview of Recent Research and Implications for Foreign Aid. In Lael Brainard and Derek Chollet, Editors (Ed.), *Too Poor for Peace? Global Poverty, Conflict and Security in the 21st Century*. Brookings Institution Press.

¹³ Ibid 12, pp. 54–55.

¹⁴ Ibid 12, pp. 55.

¹⁵ Ibid 6.

The basic premise of the deprivation hypothesis is that environmental and demographic shocks/pressures contribute to landlessness, unemployment, and resource scarcity – a scarcity of resources that the disenfranchised need on a day-to-day basis.

Further, if environmental and demographic shocks persist, then as individuals experience greater levels of poverty, the level of frustration experienced by said individuals because of their circumstances increases to the point wherein the eventuality is (a reoccurrence of) violent uprising. According to Kahl (2006), the main reproof of the deprivation hypothesis is that it over-predicts the possibility of conflict: In other words, if poverty and inequality are the only variable required to ignite widespread violence, then, by extension, the whole world would be embroiled in conflict, since more than half of the world's population lives in poverty.

Poverty and inequality are essential to the political instability mix, but are not sufficient as the only contributors to the mix. Beyond over-predicting the possibility of conflict, the deprivation hypothesis also obscures the role of the state or governing institutions: Strong capable states are usually able to employ administrative or coercive means to deter or repress violence (Kahl, 2007). As such, one can make room for the possibility that – in the context of both a high level of frustration, coupled with a weak and failing state – the likelihood of violence increases, according to the critics (Homer-Dixon, 2006; Clausen, 2011) of the deprivation hypothesis. This critique lends itself to the assessment of a second hypothesis from the neo-Malthusian school of thought, known as the state failure hypothesis.

War as a catalyst for state failure

The state failure hypothesis surmises that both population and environmental pressures will generate economic strains that weaken state capabilities. The main hypothetical expectation of the state failure hypothesis is that demographic and environmental stressors (e.g., resource scarcity, overpopulation, and climate degradation) engender violent internal conflict because said stressors enfeeble a state's institutional capacity¹⁶. The alternate possibility that the state failure hypothesis presents is that both population and environmental pressures already coexist within the context of an already weakened state. Kahl (2006) contends that the state failure hypothesis also misses a few factors: The first being that states do not need to completely collapse in order for large scale civil strikes to manifest; and, violence does not necessarily need to emanate from the level of angry social groups upwards to the level of the state.

Oftentimes, violence begins at the state level, moving downwards and towards the population – thus, states (themselves) are capable of instigating violence (Kahl, 2006).

¹⁶ See pp 25-51: Kahl, C. H. (2006). States, scarcity, and civil strife in the developing world. Princeton University Press.

Elites feeling threatened by societal disturbances will engage in divide-and-conquer tactics in order to maintain control: For example, the Rwandan genocide was not a Hutu bottom-up, genocidal campaign but, instead, was a top-down campaign waged by the elite Tutsis against the Hutus (Kahl, 2007).

Theisen et al. (2013) references Kahl (2006) in elucidating that the mutual symbiosis that exists between (highly) politically exclusive institutions (e.g., absolute monarchies; legal de jure disenfranchisement (apartheid)) and ancient ethnic cleavages (e.g., church vs. state; capitalist vs. industrialist worker) is crucial in determining whether demographic and environmental stressors will fuel violent conflict (p. 614). The study by Theisen et al. surmises that the relationship between environmental stressors and armed conflict yielded weak and inconsistent empirical evidence (2013). Fortna (2004) writes that intrastate ethnic fractionalization impacts the possibility that a state will experience civil war; expounding that identity conflicts are markedly grave because they tend towards irrepressibility – i.e., a "perpetual state of Hobbesian anarchy observable in many African countries", for example (Arowolo, 2024, p. 5).

Post June 30, 1960, after the Democratic Republic of Congo won the liberation struggle against Belgian colonial rule, civil war ensued nearly instantaneously (Gascoigne, 2001), and has continuously waxed and waned, thereafter. Locke (2010) contends that Belgian decolonization policies did not allow for the establishment of a governing system that would successfully integrate the myriad ethnicities that exist in the DRC. Additionally, Western intervention strategies, after the Congolese independence movement, crippled the DRC's ability to unite the plethora of ethnic groups within the country's borders, ultimately creating (and nurturing) an atmosphere for a protracted civil war (Locke, 2010). The World Bank (2004) reports that DRC citizens live in the aftermath of decades of civil war and years of unfettered economic mismanagement. In September 2003, a provisional administration, established with the goal of being representative of most of the ethnic groups represented in the civil war, ushered in stalemate between warring factions and fostered a political environment that allowed for economic and social reintegration; however, civil strife still proves problematic in many regions in the East that have heavy concentrations of non-renewable resources (minerals and fossil fuels) (World Bank, 2005).

Ethnic fractionalization, geographic conditions (resource overabundance), socioeconomic pathologies (weak to non-existent institutions), coupled with a fast growing youth bulge make the DRC a ripe conflict zone – which may serve to explain the country's current paradoxical state. In terms of resource wealth, the country is unrivaled. The DRC is rich in mineral wealth, "yet occupying forces are plundering not only its diamonds but also valuable gold and coltan reserves... In terms of its untapped mineral wealth, the DRC is one of the richest countries in the world. Its soil is reputed to contain every mineral listed on the periodic table and these minerals are found in concentrations high enough to make metal analysts weep" (The Washington Post, 2001).

Yet, paradoxically, in spite of its resource abundance, a sizeable majority of Congolese citizens live on the equivalent of US\$0.20 per person per day – and, incredibly, 80% of the country's inhabitants survive on under \$1 per day; most are undernourished, eating less than 66% of the daily calorie requirement (World Bank, 2005). The alternative to the neo-Malthusian deprivation hypothesis is the “resource abundance” hypothesis, which contends that an abundance of resources fuels violence, whether by creating a tempting “honey pot” that attracts looters or by subsidizing institutional pathologies (the well-known “resource curse”).

Poor states are also fragile in the sense that violence can erupt at any point in time, and governments of these states are, oftentimes, too weak to provide adequate responses. Weak institutions plague the governments of poor countries – these countries often have a lean/maladapted tax base, i.e, insufficient fiscal funds to build and maintain support for professional security forces. If property rights cannot be secured, capital flight is likely, as is a vulnerability to corruption. States with maladapted taxation structures are likely to encounter recurrent shortages of foreign exchange, and “capital-starved countries experiencing foreign exchange shortages” (Bradshaw and Huang, 1991, pg. 336) are vulnerable to exploitation¹⁷ especially since capital-starved countries must agree to the terms set by the core lender, if a development loan agreement is to be secured (Bradshaw and Huang, 1991).

Official development assistance provided to weak states has been found to stifle wealth creation incentives, when considering the role that government plays in incentivizing and interacting with its citizens (Moyo, 2009; Mwenda, A. 2007). An aid-dependent government is likely to abandon fiscal planning and responsibility in favor of foreign aid donations that allow such a government to escape responsibility and avoid answering to citizens about the allocation of state funds (Moyo, 2009). State leadership is a function of legitimacy – legitimacy provides a leader with the political leverage to remain in office. Through the promise to deliver public goods – i.e., roads, hospitals and clinics, and primary education – governing bodies and agency principles are able to map out their fiscal survival through inter-state fund raising activities (Mwenda, 2007). Thus, whether driven by self-interest or term longevity, a fiscally conservative state is more likely to govern using structured approaches to wealth generating incentives, based on clearly delineated economic policy (Moyo, 2009).

¹⁷ Wimberley, D. (1990). Investment dependence and alternative explanations of Third World mortality: A cross-national study. *American Sociological Review*, 55(1), 75-91.

Governments with strong institutions usually collaborate with local wealth creating agents (local entrepreneurs; businessmen and women; and, educated, enterprising industry leaders) in order to strategize about economic opportunities, policies, and institutional frameworks capable of strengthening business and industrial sectors to generate consistent tax revenue streams, which are then re-invested, downstream, to sustain long-term economic expansion (Moyo, 2009). Weak institutions that are dependent on aid, often deny their citizens—who possess wealth-generating potential—essential interactions that should not only create an avenue for wealth generating incentives, but should also give the government a reason to be fiscally responsible with the allocation of state resources to those industry representatives capable of equitable redistribution.

The factors contributing to state weakness vary considerably from state to state. Based on the notion that poverty leads to economic insecurity (and sometimes conflict), and also considering the preceding discussion, one could reason that the destabilizing effects of conflicts, demographic, ethnographic, and environmental challenges intermingle, making it difficult for agency principles and the institutions within a state to provide a broad range of public goods and services – particularly when political instability is already at play. Scholars (Diamond, 1992; Kahl, 2006; Gerschewski, 2013; Lipset, 1959; Moyo, 2009) argue that an intricate interrelatedness exists between poverty, insecurity, institutional weakness, and a state's ability to carry out its most basic functions.

At the core of this discussion is extant evidence within the literature (Kahl, 2006; Gerschewski, 2013; Locke, 2010; Moyo, 2009; Mwenda, 2007) suggesting that, in essence, poverty decimates state capacity by stoking conflict, enfeebling human capital, inhibiting the development of effective state institutions, and providing inoculation for corrupt agency principals. Although poverty feeds state weakness, inherently, state weakness is the outgrowth of other externalities (i.e., capacity deficits) – including, but not limited to, the absence of political legitimacy, lack of ineffective economic governance and governing structure, the inability to both provide security on-the-ground, and inadequate measures for safeguarding property rights.

These compounding deficiencies contribute to the weakening of a state's ability to adequately perform its most basic functions and provide essential services to the population. Also hindered by these compounding deficiencies is the state's ability to incentivize economic growth activities among its citizenry – activities which could potentially fund the provision of public goods. Overall, findings within the literature (Kahl, 2006; Kahl, 2007; Gerschewski, 2013; Locke, 2010; Moyo, 2009; Mwenda, 2007) suggest that demographic, ethnographic, and environmental insecurities contribute to state poverty by acting as stressors, igniting conflict, and fostering political instability.

Further, extant literature (Beck and Hüser, 2015; Clausen, 2011; Kahl, 2006; Kahl, 2007; Lederach, 1997; Mearsheimer, 2014) supports the idea that a cyclical interrelatedness exists between poverty (which weakens state institutions) and economic insecurity (which breeds conflict and further hampers the functional capacity of a state to provide basic services).

Agentic capacity: Democratic vs. autocratic regimes

Clarke and Stone (2008) establish that although democracy is a bedrock concept within political science, a clear cut definition of democracy continues to evade academics (Russett, 1993; Diamond, 1992; Muravchik, 1991), who concede the concept is difficult to define. Schumpeter (1943) frames the "democratic method" as an institutional arrangement for gaining political consensus, which is reached "by means of a competitive struggle for the people's vote."¹⁸

Defining democracy by what it is not, is the tool of choice for some scholars¹⁹. For Satori (1987), a governing system that prevents self-selection; self-imposition of power and authority; and, that denies individuals an avenue to self-assign absolute and unrestrained power, can be considered democratic. Schmitter and Karl (1996) suggest that a modern political democracy is a governing body whose principals can be held accountable for their actions in the public sphere by citizen participation in competitive and cooperative electorates.²⁰

For Huntington (1991), a twentieth-century political regime is democratic only to the extent that its most powerful actors are chosen through equitable, impartial, and recurrent elections wherein nominees compete for votes without restraint, and practically all adults represented in the population can exercise their right to vote. For the Western world, democracy has been beneficial mostly because of the civil liberties it prescribes (Heilbroner, 1999; Tsoulfidis, 2010; Caporaso and Levine, 1992). Traceably, the lives of those who live in democratic societies have been enhanced through the liberties that democracies provide, including but not limited to, the promotion and recognition of individual liberties – such as, the freedom of expression, freedom of conscience, and freedom to own private property (Caporaso and Levine, 1992; Heilbroner, 1999). Democracy is not without its shortfalls, however, for those states with fledgling democracies, the lives of their citizens may see marked improvements (Lynn-Jones, 1998).

Democracy is expected to contribute to international peace. The prevalence of peace, the crystallization of alliances, economic development, political stability, and the advancement of social indicators are conceptually hailed as positive externalities associated with a functioning democratic system.

¹⁸ Joseph Schumpeter, 1943. *Capitalism, Socialism, and Democracy*, p. 269.

¹⁹ Schmitter and Karl. 1996) "What Democracy Is ... and Is Not"; Sartori (1996) *The Theory of Democracy Revisited*.

²⁰ Philippe C. Schmitter and Terry Lynn Karl, "What Democracy Is ... and Is Not," in Larry Diamond and Marc F. Plattner, eds., *The Global Resurgence of Democracy*, p. 50.

The Kantian contribution to the concept of democracy revolves around the notion of perpetual peace, deemed achievable only through universal democracy and international cooperation²¹. The modern-day definition of peace has partial linkages to the concept of 'democratic peace,' which underscores the idea that well established democratic states do not become embroiled in international wars with one another, and the mutual use of threat or force by one democratic state against another is either low or uncommon²².

Agentic capacity: The role of a peaceful democracy

Is democracy the driver of peace? Kantian peace suggests that laws enacted by the republic, free trade within the international realm, and an alliance of interdependent republics provide the prerequisites for perpetual peace – realizable only via democratic tenets.²³ However, the Kantian umbrella view of democratic peace is incomplete because it obscures the benefits of peace that are not included in Kant's liberal peace elements.²⁴ Further, the concept of democratic peace hides instructive theoretical debates concerning whether or not democracy is the true engine behind peace: The concept of democratic peace buries, within its definition, the degree to which peace already exists as a phenomenon of other polities²⁵.

To test the possibility that democracies engender peace, Oneal and Russett (1999) begin their empirical analysis with the assumption that within the international system, anarchy reigns supreme, therefore, war is inherent to the international system. This implies that, power is crucial to security; and, the federation of interdependent republics within the global system must act decisively, using power politics to produce – if only temporarily – respite from conflict.²⁶

Despite this Hobbesian tendency for violence, states nested within a democratic cradle do not fight each other. Rather – restrained by realist constraints of power, alliances, and distance – democratic states concern themselves with the balance of power, and the coexistence of shared national interests represented by their allied existence in a democratic realm. What this principle of cooperative alliances obscures is that many states separated by distance have little cause to fight each other, generally speaking, as distance nullifies mutual threats. The realist approach to this discussion is that there are some states within the international realm that do have a reason to be engaged in conflict, and as such, Oneal and Russett (1999) used this realist perspective as a baseline measure for assessing the impact of the Kantian peace elements on the theoretical peace model.

²¹ Oneal and Russett. 1999. "The Kantian peace: The pacific benefits of democracy, interdependence, and international organizations, p. 1-2.

²² Ibid 2.

²³ Ibid 2.

²⁴ Oneal, J. R., and Russett, B. 1999. "The Kantian peace: The pacific benefits of democracy, interdependence, and international organizations.

²⁵ Ibid 6.

²⁶ Ibid 2, pg. 1.

To the realist variable, Oneal and Russett added measures for three (3) Kantian constraints and hypothesized that: i) democracies are prone to use force less frequently, particularly against other democracies; ii) trade creates economic incentives that are important to the maintenance of peaceful relations; and iii) international organizations constrain actors by using different methods that encourage peace.

Based on the notion that the modern international system is anarchic, and thus, far from a peaceful federation of democratic states, both realist and Kantian factors are expected to collide and have an impact on interstate relations²⁷. Also assessed was the impact of intergovernmental organizations (IGOs) on the likelihood of conflict at the dyadic level of analysis. The expectation for the IGO variable was that democracies are no more likely to fight each other than are other polities; however, the liberal philosophy on the pacific effects of trade finds contradiction with the notion that the division of trade profits is likely to spark conflict between large and small states.²⁸ One could argue that democratic states join IGOs in order to manage adversarial disputes – although the effectiveness of such memberships is minimal, the United Nations being one such example²⁹.

Rational choice theorists cite audience costs as the reason that political actors combine economic interests with maintaining peaceful interstate relations. Apprehensive of the domestic political ramifications of botched trade deals, policymakers avoid violent conflict with states that are their economic trade partners³⁰.

The constructivist perspective maintains that peaceful relations among democracies is merely a consequence of their shared security interests vis-à-vis the presence of anarchy in the international realm (Wendt, 1992). In other words, shared security relationships are governed, not by geography or economic power, but by shared identities (allyship) and mutual concerns. Thus, based on this constructivist view point, the Kantian peace model cannot guard against spurious alternatives when the political inclination of a regime is called into question (Lederach, 1997). A similar conclusion can be drawn if the democratic peace concept is applied regarding the hegemonic power of the United States to either suppress conflict among its allies or mediate East-West differences that are not rooted in regime preferences.

The expectation for such scenarios is that one would not find “separate peace among democratic states in other periods evincing different patterns of interstate relations”.³¹ In other words, dating as far back as 1885, before the U.S became a democratic hegemon, peaceful relationships existed between states.

²⁷ Ibid 6.

²⁸ Ibid 6.

²⁹ Ibid 2, pg. 5.

³⁰ Ibid 2, pg. 6.

³¹ Ibid 2, pg. 2.

Thus, when the historical domain is considered, attributing peaceful partnerships only to the need for a democracy to safeguard its economic alliances will likely over-predict the true nature of the underlying relationship between economic alliances and democracy.

Realists acknowledge that international institutions, like NATO, can preserve peace among their members, only to the extent to which such institutions can contribute additional might to the deterrent effect that individual members already possess, through the sheer strength of their individual military units (Mearsheimer, 2014). In addition to the concept of “liberal peace,” which is created when trade partners are mutually interested in constraining the use of force, Kant emphasized the utility of international law and organization (Danilovic and Clare, 2007; Kant 2006, pp 74-78). Oneal and Russett (1999) found that, during the cold war era, the presence of trade relationships and intergovernmental networks found correlations with reductions in the number of militarized interstate disputes – effects which the authors attribute as one of the many benefits of democracy.

State-sponsored peace: Democracies vs. autocracies

Wendt (1999) contends that the state of world politics has slowly transitioned from Hobbesian anarchy to a Lockean system wherein security issues are regulated by norms that recognize the right of sovereign states to exist. As such, states face less of a threat of being wiped off the map, as in historical times. The Kantian model predicts that autocratic or other non-democratic polities are more likely to use force and engage in violent conflict than democratic regimes (Kant, 2006). However, democracies are more likely to win decisive victories during their wars than are autocracies because autocrats face greater security concerns of a weakened stronghold during war (Reiter and Stam, 2002). On the international front, autocratic regimes have to take precautions to prevent situations wherein they are punished by the global market for inciting violence that disrupts international trade and investment relationships between trading states (Oechslin, 2014).

Revisiting the historical context of peace, the exclusion of women from the franchise during earlier periods could have significantly lowered the tendency that “democratic” states would avoid conflict – in other words, democracies could have appeared conflict prone to conflict, prior to the enfranchisement of women: This is especially noteworthy within the context of the contemporary United States – women are significantly more averse to war than men; and, women are likely to be influenced by this aversion when they cast their ballots (Russett, 1993; Eichenberg, 2003). Conversely, the enfranchisement of women in the 1920s could potentially have altered the trajectory of democratic states towards more war averse tendencies (Eichenberg, 2003).

Karatnycky (1997), in contrasting democracies and autocratic regimes, writes that even imperfect and illiberal democracies are likely to offer more civil liberties than autocracies.

Gerchowski³² illustrates that the stability of an autocratic regime – regardless of its subtype – can be explained with reference to three pillars of stability: legitimation, repression, and co-optation. These pillars allow autocrats to avert regime breakdowns stemming from three possible sources: i) ordinary citizens who choose to rebel or galvanize uprisings; ii) organized resistance from oppositional forces; and, iii) intra-elite fractions that divide strategically important elites against the ruling elites (Gerchowski, 2013).

Since autocrats have no need for support from their people – in contrast to democracies – the concept of a “legitimate autocracy” is an oxymoron, according to Gerchowski (2013). From a more pragmatic perspective, based on the critique that autocrats are not bound to legitimacy constraints, Gerchowski defines legitimation according to the Weberian tradition of “legitimacy belief”, which is free of contradictions rooted in the normative translations of a legitimate autocracy (p. 18). In so doing, Weber’s goal was to re-classify political rule, without reference to normative judgments that imply that there is a “right” approach to ruling (pp. 213, 215-6).

Subjective inherent heuristic inclinations may lead to an early deduction that a legitimate autocracy cannot exist (by definition), however, upon closer examination, Gerchowski points out that autocratic regimes are “performance-dependent” to some degree (2013, p. 19). Studying legitimate autocracies involves a reliance on economic indicators, such as the Human Development Index, or surveying general population indices – these metrics, in some respect, point to the reality that autocrats must deliver economically satisfying performances to maintain their “social contract” with the general populace (Gerchowski, 2013, p. 19). This social contract is described as a reciprocal relationship in which political deference is guaranteed in return for relatively satisfactory economic performances (Heydemann, 1999). As a case in point, the “Arab Spring” grew violent when disillusioned citizens chose to withdraw from long-term social contracts, put in place by populist authoritarian states (Beck and Hüser, 2015, p. 83).

State-sponsored economic growth: Democracies vs. autocracies

According to Olson (1993): “It is no accident that the countries that have reached the highest level of economic performance across generations are all stable democracies” (pp. 572-3). Although democracies have been praised for their ability to nurture long-run economic performance, democracy does not always usher in prosperity: In some instances, within the sub-Saharan context, democratic instruments designed with the intention to address capital insufficiencies have been found to hamper development (Lynn-Jones, 1998; Moyo, 2009; Wimberley, 1990; Frey and Field, 2000; Shandra et. al, 2004). Some democracies – India and the Philippines, for example – have shown weakening economic indicators over the last few years; yet, other democratic states (e.g., South Korea and the United States) rank among the wealthiest societies in existence (Lynn-Jones, 1998; Acemoglu and Robinson, 2012).

³² Gerschewski, J. (2013). The three pillars of stability: legitimation, repression, and co-optation in autocratic regimes.

Some authoritarian regimes report impressive short-run economic records that outperform U.S. growth rates – for example, over several decades, the annual gross national product (GNP) for the Soviet Union grew at a rate that outmatched comparable U. S. rates (Lynn-Jones, 1998). However, the long-term sustainability of these growth spurts usually presents a challenge for autocratic countries. Olson (1993) writes that although a relatively poor country controlled by a dictator with strong economic policies may experience extremely rapid growth, this growth will last “only for the ruling span of one or two dictators” (pp. 572).

Democracies have more stable long-run economic growth trajectories than autocracies mainly because democracies (especially liberal democracies) are more likely to have legalized and legitimized market economies, which tend to generate stable, long-run economic growth (Lynn-Jones, 1998; Sarel, 1996). Several of the world's leading economies – including the United States, Japan, the Asian “tigers” in Southeast Asia, and the OECD members – have legalized market economies (Lynn-Jones, 1998). According to Brainard, Chollet and LaFleur (2007), “resource abundance poses ... dangerous challenges...” to security and many of the disenfranchised “suffer from a poverty of plenty”.³³ Brainard and Cholet explain that an abundance of natural resources feeds the pathological tendencies of authoritarian and corrupt governing institutions: In the sub-Saharan region, similar to foreign aid dependency pathologies, resource wealth has been shown to stifle wealth creation incentives (2007).

Further, the rent-seeking behavior of elites in authoritarian regimes, disenfranchises domestic citizens through a series of negative externalities, e.g., “honey pot effects” (i.e., militants organize to loot government coffers); corruption; and, coups – coups because aid concentrated in government coffers attracts violent anti-government groups seeking access to said coffers (Brainard, Chollet and LaFleur, 2007; Moyo, 2009).

Concluding thoughts

This study assessed how democratic and autocratic regimes behave in the international arena, and it began with an exposition of extant attempts made by academics (Beck and Hüser, 2015; Clarke and Stone, 2008; Diamond, 1992; Gascoigne, 2001; Huntington, 1991) to expand the criteria for democracy. By identifying the role of civil conflict – in juxtaposition with the notion that varying degrees of democracy exist, this study posits that neatly carved out constructions of democratic and autocratic regimes exist only in theory.

Some states may be more democratic than others, which will affect the kinds of monetary, fiscal, military, and political policies at play both domestically and on the international scene. Some autocratic regimes, like Saudi Arabia, are more advanced on several socioeconomic indicators than comparable but weak/fledgling democratic states.

³³ Too Poor for Peace? Global Poverty, Conflict and Security in the 21st Century, edited by Lael Brainard and Derek Chollet. Pg. 6

Further, an autocratic regime like Saudi Arabia could, arguably, be indistinguishable from a comparatively strong democratic state – differing only in terms of the civil liberties awarded to citizens on opposite sides of the political aisle. A state's political regime also impacts the probability of conflict: Democracies are expected to contribute to peace, whilst democratic-autocratic dyads were found, by Oneal and Russett (1999), to be the most conflict-prone, especially during the cold war era.

In the event of an international dispute, Robinson (1950) writes that even non-democratic regimes may resort to calling upon regional or international organizations for assistance with dispute settlements – rather than face the political, military, and economic penalties (imposed by the liberal international community) as a consequence of engaging in conflict. Thus, at the system level, and according to Oneal and Russett, Kantian influences “may have beneficial effects on the behavior of dyads that are not particularly democratic, economically interdependent, or involved in international organizations” (1999, p. 9). In other words, authoritarian regimes may, from time to time, exhibit democratic behavioral characteristics, if only for short-term gain.

Hybrids of both democracy and autocracy have proven problematic in many sub-Saharan African states, particularly in the contexts of the abundance (and scarcity) of both renewable and non-renewable resources. Although these political delineations (i.e., autocratic vs. democratic) are important, the key differences between these regimes are, oftentimes, also context-specific: Thus differentiating a democratic regime from an autocratic regime is, in certain respects, a matter of educated judgement, as the very definitions and theoretical constructions of said regimes remain unfixed. Be that as it may, easily identifiable provisions supporting basic civil liberties can serve to highlight, and perhaps even contrast, the key differences between autocratic and democratic states.

In short, concerning the role of the state in promoting economic growth, public goods, and political stability, findings within the literature (Kahl, 2006; Kahl, 2007; Gerschewski, 2013; Locke, 2010; Moyo, 2009; Mwenda, 2007) suggest that demographic, ethnographic, and environmental insecurities contribute to state poverty by acting as stressors, igniting conflict, and fostering political instability. Further, extant literature (Beck and Hüser, 2015; Clausen, 2011; Kahl, 2006; Kahl, 2007; Lederach, 1997; Mearsheimer, 2014) supports the idea that a cyclical interrelatedness exists between poverty (which weakens state institutions) and economic insecurity (which breeds conflict and further hampers the functional capacity of a state to provide basic services).

Concerning the key differences between democratic and autocratic regimes, and how regime type influences the promotion of economic growth, the provision of public goods, and political stability – the literature (Oneal and Russett, 1999; Robinson 1950; Russett, 1993) suggests democracy is expected to contribute to international peace: The prevalence of peace, the crystallization of alliances, economic development, political stability, and the advancement

of social indicators are conceptually hailed as positive externalities associated with a functioning democratic system. Nevertheless, this Hobbesian tendency for violence, states nested within a democratic cradle do not fight each other. Rather – restrained by realist constraints of power, alliances, and distance – democratic states concern themselves with the balance of power, and the coexistence of shared national interests represented by their allied existence in a democratic realm.

Oneal and Russett (1999) assessed three (3) Kantian constraints and hypothesized that: i) democracies are prone to use force less frequently, particularly against other democracies; ii) trade creates economic incentives that are important to the maintenance of peaceful relations; and iii) international organizations constrain actors by using different methods that encourage peace. The findings by Oneal and Russett (1999) suggest that – concerning the promotion of economic growth, the provision of public goods, and political stability – democracies provide a more stable environment for a state's agentic capacities to flourish. However, based on the notion that the modern international system is anarchic, and thus, far from a peaceful federation of democratic states, both realist and Kantian factors are expected to collide and have an impact on interstate relations (Rogowski, 1987). Kahl (2007) identifies large scale civil strife, or organized political violence within a country as the causal variable in specifying the equation for a properly functioning state. According to Miguel (2007, p. 51), "the poverty-violence link is arguably the most robust finding in the growing research literature investigating the causes of civil wars" that discernably cripple a state's economic capabilities. On the global stage, Oechslin (2014) posits that autocratic regimes may find themselves on thin ice concerning domestic situations that could potentially create backlash from the global market, in response to, and as repudiation against, violence that disrupts international trade and investment relationships between trading states.

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